

English Verb Patterns Reference Guide

A Comprehensive Grammar Guide to Verbs Followed by Gerunds and Bare Infinitives

Part 1: Verbs Always Followed by Gerunds (-ing)

In English, certain verbs must be followed directly by a gerund (the verb form ending in -ing) when another action immediately follows them. Below are the primary categories and high-frequency structures.

1. High-Frequency Everyday Verbs

- **Avoid:** Prevent or stop oneself from doing something. → *She avoids eating late at night.*
- **Enjoy:** Take pleasure in doing something. → *They enjoy playing board games on weekends.*
- **Finish:** Bring an activity to an end. → *He finished writing his detailed research report.*
- **Mind:** Object to (commonly used in questions/negatives). → *Would you mind closing the window?*
- **Keep / Keep on:** Continue doing an action repeatedly. → *Keep practicing, and your pronunciation will improve.*
- **Practice:** Perform an activity regularly to improve skill. → *You need to practice speaking English fluently.*

2. Planning, Timing, & Decision Verbs

- **Postpone / Delay / Put off:** Arrange for an event/action to take place at a later time. → *We had to postpone holding the annual conference.*
- **Consider:** Think carefully about doing something. → *Have you considered moving to a new city?*
- **Suggest / Recommend:** Put forward an idea or plan. → *I highly suggest taking a short rest before continuing.*
- **Quit / Give up:** Stop doing an activity or habit. → *He quit smoking several years ago.*
- **Risk:** Expose oneself to the possibility of something harmful. → *Don't risk losing all your valuable savings.*

3. Emotional, Reporting, & Complex Verbs

- **Appreciate:** Feel grateful for something. → *I greatly appreciate your helping us with this project.*
- **Admit:** Confess to an action. → *The suspect admitted stealing the expensive jewelry.*
- **Deny:** State that something is not true. → *He firmly denied taking the confidential files.*
- **Involve:** Include as a necessary part. → *The new job involves traveling across Europe.*

- **Resent:** Feel bitterness or indignation about something. → *She resents being treated like a novice.*

PREPOSITION TRAP: Be careful with phrasal verbs ending in the preposition 'to' (e.g., look forward to, be used to, object to). Because 'to' functions as a preposition here rather than an infinitive marker, it must also be followed by a gerund (e.g., 'I am looking forward to meeting you', NOT 'to meet').

Part 2: Verbs Always Followed by Bare Infinitives (Base Form)

A bare infinitive is an infinitive without the particle 'to'. Certain categories of verbs—specifically modals, causatives, verbs of perception, and set expressions—require this form.

1. Causative Verbs (Verb + Object + Bare Infinitive)

- **Make:** Force or cause someone to perform an action. → *The instructor made us rewrite the entire essay.*
- **Let:** Allow or permit someone to do something. → *Please let me explain what actually happened.*
- **Have:** Delegate or give responsibility to someone. → *I will have my assistant send you the document details.*

2. Verbs of Perception (Verb + Object + Bare Infinitive)

Note: Use the bare infinitive when you perceive a complete action from start to finish.

- **See:** Observe a complete action. → *I saw her cross the street safely.*
- **Hear:** Perceive a sound or voice. → *We heard the crowd cheer when the team scored.*
- **Watch / Feel:** Witness an event unfolding. → *Did you watch him perform live on stage?*

3. Idiomatic Expressions & Special Cases

- **Had better:** Used for giving strong advice or warnings. → *You had better finish your assignments before midnight.*
- **Would rather:** Used to express preference. → *I would rather stay home than go out tonight.*
- **Why / Why not:** Used for making direct suggestions. → *Why not try calling their support desk directly?*

- **Help:** Can take a bare infinitive or full infinitive with no shift in meaning. → *Can you help me carry these heavy boxes?*

Summary Reference Table

Category	Key Target Verbs	Correct Example Pattern
Gerunds (-ing)	avoid, enjoy, finish, keep, mind, consider, postpone, suggest	I enjoy learning new languages.
Causatives	make, let, have (with object)	Let him speak without interruption.
Perception Verbs	see, hear, watch, feel, notice (complete action)	I heard someone knock at the door.
Idioms / Special	had better, would rather, why not, help	You had better hurry up.